



# Acknowledgement of Country

We acknowledge the Traditional Owners of the lands, seas, skies and waterways from across Queensland.

We pay our respect to the Elders past and present, for they hold the memories, traditions, the culture and hopes of Aboriginal peoples and Torres Strait Islander peoples.

A better understanding and respect for Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander cultures develops an enriched appreciation of Australia's cultural heritage and can lead to reconciliation.

This is essential to the maturity of Australia as a nation and fundamental to the development of an Australian identity.



## **Produced by:**

Department of Education, Queensland

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# Intentional decision-making to support children's executive function

This resource explores intentional decision-making to support children's executive function skills. Executive function refers to how children think, plan and stay focused. It helps them remember instructions, switch or move between tasks and keep trying when things get challenging. These skills include working memory, inhibitory control and cognitive flexibility, observed through behaviours like persistence, adaptability, and problem-solving.

The Queensland kindergarten learning guideline (QKLG, 2018, p.29) defines intentional teaching as 'an active process that embraces and builds on children's knowledge, perspectives, capabilities and interests. Through this approach, children also act intentionally when they actively engage with others and make choices through play.'

Teachers and educators engage in intentional decision-making by making thoughtful, informed choices that extend children's thinking, communication and deep understanding. This involves drawing on curriculum frameworks, observations and professional knowledge to plan and adapt learning experiences that respond to each child's strengths, interests and needs.

The Early Years learning Framework (EYLF V2.0, p. 32) shares that 'feeling valued, successful and accepted enables all children to tackle new things, express themselves, work through differences and take calculated risks.' It also recognises that, "for Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander children, awareness of their kinship networks and connections to Country are important to development of identity."

The EYLF learning outcomes and the QKLG learning and development areas support children's ongoing progress in executive function related skills such as persistence, adaptability and problem solving. They promote the development of responsive kindergarten programs through intentional decision-making.

## Strengthening Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander perspectives

Consideration of Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander world views is vital for embedding and strengthening Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander perspectives. It acknowledges the diversity of Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander culture, traditions, languages, historical impacts and provides teachers and educators with contextualised awareness of protocols of the lands on which they work.

'Educators think deeply and seek assistance where possible, through engaging with Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander people, about how to embed Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander perspectives in the philosophy of the setting, their planning and implementation of curriculum' (EYLF V2.0, 2022, p. 6)

### The intentional teaching strategies and learning experiences align with:

#### Early Years Learning Framework (EYLF) Learning outcomes:

- Children have a strong sense of identity
- Children have a strong sense of wellbeing
- Children are confident and involved learners

#### Principles:

- Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander perspectives
- Cultural responsiveness

#### Queensland kindergarten learning guideline (QKLG) – Learning and development areas:

- Identity
- Wellbeing
- Active learning

#### Principles:

- High expectations, equity and respect for diversity
- Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander Torres Strait Islander Perspectives
- Sustainability
- Creative inclusive learning environments

**NOTE:** Connections to the EYLF and QKLG are a starting point and may vary across intentional teaching strategies and learning experiences in different contexts.

## Persistence – Intentional teaching strategies

|                           |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |                                       |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
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| <b>Collaborating</b>      | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Build partnerships with Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander families, children and community members.</li> <li>• Invite them to share their insights and feedback on everyday practices.</li> <li>• Invite families and Elders in to be part of your services cultural journey. For example, codesign a Reconciliation Action Plan to work towards setting up a culturally safe environment.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                    | <b>Scaffolding or differentiating</b> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Create a culturally safe space using flags, artefacts, images and books that reflect local cultures.</li> <li>• Offer strategies and tools to help children persist with challenges or setbacks.</li> <li>• Adjust challenges so every child can persist at their own level.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| <b>Researching</b>        | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Develop relationships with local communities to build an understanding of what protocols look like in the community.</li> <li>• Invite families and community members to share Yarning Circle protocol with children. Consider permissions needed to run a yarning circle.</li> <li>• Encourage children to ask questions and explore why Yarning Circles are important.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          | <b>Challenging</b>                    | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Give children tasks that gradually increase in difficulty.</li> <li>• Encourage them to keep trying and support them when needed.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| <b>Making connections</b> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Welcome Elders, families, and community members into the kindergarten to share knowledge, stories and experiences that foster cultural identity and cultural pride.</li> <li>• Build strong connections with local Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander Dreaming and creation stories. Connect them to children's interests with local landmarks, animals and cultural knowledge.</li> <li>• Ensure the learning environment promotes cultural safety for Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander families through respectful relationships, shared experiences and inclusion of their knowledge and perspectives.</li> </ul> | <b>Encouraging</b>                    | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Praise effort and perseverance, not just the end result.</li> <li>• Use verbal and non-verbal cues such as a thumbs up, smile or nod.</li> <li>• Highlight when children show persistence in their play.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| <b>Reflecting</b>         | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Invite children to reflect on what helped them persist.</li> <li>• Encourage them to consider the importance of cultural identity and cultural pride for themselves, their families and the wider community.</li> <li>• Ask open-ended questions to help children notice the strategies they used.</li> <li>• Use the environment as a 'third teacher' and explore ways to create learning opportunities indoors and outdoors.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                    | <b>Listening</b>                      | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Create opportunities for children to practice turn-taking and deep listening through words, gestures or body language e.g., Yarning circles or going on cultural walks, listening to the sounds of Country.</li> <li>• Recognise that listening can look different; children may move, avoid eye contact or use other strategies, yet are still actively engaged and listening in their own way.</li> <li>• Introduce Dadirri for deep listening and quiet awareness and explore similar local practices. Acknowledge Miriam-Rose Ungunmerr for this teaching.</li> <li>• Invite Elders and community members to share their stories and knowledge. Model deep listening to ensure cultural safety in the learning.</li> <li>• Embed the children's and family's cultural identities, home languages and interests into the kindergarten program.</li> </ul> |
|                           |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       | <b>Modelling</b>                      | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Share your own stories of persistence and not giving up.</li> <li>• Read and discuss cultural dreamtime stories that demonstrate persistence to the children.</li> <li>• Show how to break a task into steps and celebrate progress along the way.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |

## Persistence – Learning experiences

|                             |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |                                       |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
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| <b>Puzzles</b>              | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Offer puzzles with different levels of challenge.</li> <li>• Model strategies like grouping or sorting pieces and celebrate persistence and effort.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           | <b>Collaborative games</b>            | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Play cooperative and traditional group games that encourage teamwork, sharing and persistence.</li> <li>• Use yarning circles with children to plan and discuss games, supporting collaboration, decision-making and persistence in play.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| <b>Art</b>                  | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Explore traditional art that require attention to detail and perseverance.</li> <li>• Discuss traditional sources of paint in the local area.</li> <li>• Collect rocks and prepare traditional painting materials e.g., ochre to connect with local cultural practices.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       | <b>Playing with natural resources</b> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Talk about where clay comes from and how it is a natural resource that we need to care for.</li> <li>• Consider using locally sourced clay or mud and discuss Caring for Country and retuning the natural materials to the land.</li> <li>• Provide clay for children to create their own sculptures.</li> <li>• Offer tools and natural materials such as flowers, sticks and bark for them to explore and experiment with.</li> <li>• Model different ways to work the natural resources. Walk on Country with local Traditional Owners to talk about the significance of local landmarks and art.</li> </ul> |
| <b>Storytelling</b>         | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Share stories reflecting the children's culture, about characters who keep trying and succeed including cultural storytelling ways and songs. Explore concepts in yarns with the children.</li> <li>• Provide puppets, props and cultural items so children can retell and keep working with a story or song in their own way. Children reflect on the characters' experiences and make connections to their own lives.</li> <li>• Invite local Elders and community members to share an oral story of persistence and trying new challenges.</li> </ul> | <b>Learning together</b>              | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Incorporate cultural values of sharing and collaboration in group experiences that require teamwork, such as traditional group games, music and movement, storytelling, role plays, plays, finger puppets, hand puppets and cooking.</li> <li>• Embed Torres Strait Islander instruments such as Warups, Kulups or Lumut to explore beat and rhythm whilst enhancing inhibitory control.</li> <li>• Plan and organise culturally significant days such as NAIDOC, Reconciliation Week. Including special family morning teas and family days.</li> </ul>                                                        |
| <b>Yarning Circles</b>      | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Use Yarning Circles indoors and outdoors to engage in deep listening, practise turn-taking and respecting others.</li> <li>• Allow the children to share how they themselves have overcome challenges.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |                                       |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| <b>Dancing</b>              | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Embed cultural dance and music to foster cultural identity and cultural pride.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |                                       |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| <b>Daily gentle rhythms</b> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Encourage children to take on small daily jobs and share responsibilities within the learning environment.</li> <li>• Connect tasks to cultural values of caring for Country, resources and community.</li> <li>• Remind children that each day is different and things change.</li> <li>• Introduce a seasonal calendar and discuss how changes in seasons affect what we do for ourselves, each other and the environment.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                  | <b>Building challenges</b>            | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Provide loose parts, natural and recycled materials for building and creating.</li> <li>• Allow free exploration of the materials indoors and outdoors, then gradually introduce specific building challenges, such as building a tall tower or creating a structure with specific features.</li> <li>• Model breaking tasks into steps and encourage children to try new approaches when things don't work.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                         |

## Adaptability – Intentional teaching strategies

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| <b>Reflecting</b>                                   | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Ask children to think about how they adapted and what strategies helped.</li> <li>Use Yarning Circles to practise listening, turn-taking and responding to new ideas.</li> <li>Give children time for silence when reflecting. Encourage them to notice and reflect on the animals, nature, and sounds around them outdoors.</li> <li>Use this time to support mindfulness and connection to Country.</li> </ul>                                |
| <b>Providing choices and learning opportunities</b> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Give children options and let them see the results of their decisions.</li> <li>Include traditional games, cooking, art, storytelling or songs that require planning and adjusting.</li> <li>Use sensory activities for children to explore and respond to new environments.</li> <li>Give children time to make choices, supporting those who find new decisions challenging or may not have had opportunities to do so culturally.</li> </ul> |
| <b>Pausing</b>                                      | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Incorporate pausing and listening to the outdoor environment – what can they hear in nature?</li> <li>Give children enough time to process information and respond during conversations and play.</li> <li>Allow them to adapt their thoughts and actions based on what they've heard or experienced.</li> <li>Take time to pause and reflect with children while they are playing.</li> </ul>                                                  |
| <b>Making connections</b>                           | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Welcome Elders, families and community into the learning space to encourage and foster cultural pride</li> <li>Help children link what they already know to new experiences.</li> <li>Guide them to use past experiences to respond to unexpected changes or events.</li> <li>Connect learning to traditional stories or games that require children to be flexible.</li> </ul>                                                                 |

### Collaborating

- Build partnerships with Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander families, children and community members.
- Invite them to share experiences, stories and cultural practices that help children respond to change.
- Recognise that some children find change difficult.
- Use yarning circles to talk about changes and introduce small steps, helping children gradually adapt to new situations.
- Encourage children to share their thoughts and ideas, supporting them to embrace change at their own pace.
- Invite families and community members to share their expertise and knowledge to help children adapt to new learning experiences.
- Invite families if they are comfortable to share their advice and feedback to improve the service. To encourage two-way sharing and learning in everyday practice.
- Collaborate with local Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander artists to create and embed cultural art programs, supporting children to explore new ideas and approaches.
- Ensure their knowledge and skills are appropriately acknowledged and remunerated.





## Adaptability – Learning experiences

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| <b>Imaginative play</b>       | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Set up imaginative play space indoors and outdoors where children explore adapting to unexpected changes or flexible thinking e.g., a shop without money or a storm during a fishing trip.</li> <li>Provide props or prompts, including traditional artifacts and tools, to help children adapt stories, games or scenarios.</li> <li>Invite children to discuss roles, negotiate and adjust actions during play, encouraging cultural values of sharing and collaboration e.g., switching roles when someone leaves or a new challenge arises.</li> </ul>                                                             | <b>Collaborative games</b>       | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Play traditional group games that involve changing rules, roles or strategies.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| <b>Excursions</b>             | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Visit the local school to help children adapt to new environments and support their transition.</li> <li>Take excursions to local parks and outdoor spaces to explore Caring for Country.</li> <li>Encourage children to share ideas about how they can care for their community.</li> <li>Record the sounds of animals and birds during excursions and replay them later to help children reflect and reconnect with their experience.</li> <li>Plan regular walks to familiar community places, such as the local library, where children can make choices and adapt to new routines with trusted adults.</li> </ul> | <b>Music and movement</b>        | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Use music and movement activities where children adapt to changes in rhythm, words or actions, including traditional songs or dances to foster cultural identity and cultural pride e.g., omit words or actions, creating opportunities for children to adapt to change.</li> <li>Invite local Elders and community to share cultural music and movement if possible.</li> <li>Where possible, translate familiar songs into home languages e.g., heads, shoulders, knees and toes.</li> <li>Gather some cultural musical instruments such as kulaps, clapsticks and drums.</li> <li>Research how these instruments were created and what dances were celebrated. Talk to local Elders and knowledge holders about this to ensure this is appropriate.</li> </ul> |
| <b>Investigation stations</b> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Set up investigation stations inside and outside, with unfamiliar resources, including natural and recycled materials, prompting children to try different strategies e.g., loose parts like shells, stones, or bark.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       | <b>Reflection and discussion</b> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Encourage children to reflect on changes or challenges by sharing ideas, talking about strategies they used or drawing in journals.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| <b>Storytelling</b>           | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Share stories with characters who adjust to new situations or unexpected events, including traditional Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander stories.</li> <li>Encourage collaborative storytelling using puppets, felt pieces or small world play.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |                                  |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| <b>Cooking together</b>       | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Invite in Elders and families to share their cultural ways of cooking.</li> <li>Create a bush tucker garden and explore the uses and purposes of native plants e.g., food or medicinal use.</li> <li>Engage children in cooking traditional foods, adjusting for ingredients, dietary needs, preferences and cultural practices.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |                                  |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |



## Problem solving – Intentional teaching strategies

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| <b>Explaining</b>  | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Show children clear problem-solving strategies and guide them to use these when faced with challenges.</li> <li>• Teach children to break tasks into smaller steps and think through each part, using examples from everyday life or traditional practices.</li> <li>• Acknowledge that there are many ways to solve a problem and invite children to share approaches from their home or from a cultural perspective.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             | <b>Reflecting</b>                                                                    | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Encourage children to reflect on what they learned, how they worked together and what they might do next time.</li> <li>• Create quiet moments to reflect outdoors e.g., listening to Country and noticing how nature shows problem-solving in action, such as animals finding food or shelter.</li> </ul> |
| <b>Researching</b> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Support children to gather information and explore different resources to solve problems including books, natural materials or community knowledge.</li> <li>• Invite them to ask questions and try different approaches, including learning from Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander stories or traditional practices.</li> <li>• Explore how climate change affects local seasons and seasonal calendars. Discuss what this means for your community and environment.</li> <li>• Research Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander perspectives that show examples of problem solving. For example, investigate the Torres Strait Islander Tagai story and how it guided navigation and seasonal decision-making.</li> </ul> |  |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| <b>Scaffolding</b> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Offer support as children work through problem-solving activities.</li> <li>• Gradually release responsibility, giving guidance only when needed to help children develop independence in generating and evaluating ideas.</li> <li>• Support children to use their home languages, gestures, drawings or familiar ways of communicating to share ideas and solve problems.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |                                                                                      |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| <b>Questioning</b> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Use open-ended questions to invite curiosity, critical thinking and flexibility in finding solutions.</li> <li>• Ask reflective questions that connect to children's experiences of Country, family and community e.g., How could we use what is around us to help solve this problem?</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |                                                                                      |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |



## Problem solving – Learning experiences

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| <b>Open-ended building</b> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Provide a variety of natural and recycled materials for children to build and create.</li><li>• Encourage children to plan, test and change their ideas as they build.</li><li>• Talk about how Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander peoples might use natural materials and traditional designs to solve problems, such as making tools or shelters.</li><li>• Invite children to share their ideas through drawings, stories or yarning.</li></ul>                                                     | <b>Story-based problem solving</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Share stories, including traditional Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander stories, where characters face challenges or make decisions.</li><li>• Talk with children about how the characters solved problems and what they learned along the way.</li><li>• Encourage children to share their own ideas or create new endings, showing how they might solve the problem differently.</li><li>• Discuss how stories hold lessons about caring for others, working together and staying connected to Country and community.</li><li>• Invite children to retell stories through drawing, movement, song, or yarning, showing how knowledge is shared in different ways and passed between people and places.</li></ul> |
| <b>Mystery box</b>         | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Create a mystery box with a mix of natural and recycled materials.</li><li>• Encourage children to explore what's inside and think of different ways to use each item.</li><li>• Support children to work together, share ideas, and solve problems in creative ways.</li><li>• Include familiar and cultural objects where possible and invite children to share their names in their home languages.</li></ul>                                                                                          |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| <b>Sensory play</b>        | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Explore nature and Country, noticing what they see, hear, and feel.</li><li>• Collect leaves, sticks, flowers, and shells to create patterns or collages.</li><li>• Pour and measure water using different containers, observing effects.</li><li>• Talk about how Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander peoples use observation and experimentation to solve problems and care for Country.</li><li>• Reflect on what worked, what could change, and how ideas connect to place and community.</li></ul> |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|                            |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   | <b>Mapping our community</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Work with children to create a map of the local town or community.</li><li>• Encourage them to identify and problem-solve how to represent important places, people and services on the map.</li><li>• Include local Traditional Owners or community members to share stories about significant sites and how people navigate and care for Country.</li><li>• Support children to use drawing, symbols and their home languages to label places and explain their ideas.</li><li>• Reflect together on how maps help us solve problems about where things are, how to get there, and who helps keep the community strong.</li></ul>                                                                                         |
|                            |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   | <b>Design thinking</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Invite children to explore a real problem that connects to their world, such as how to carry water, collect seeds, or create shade.</li><li>• Encourage them to design and test solutions using natural or recycled materials.</li><li>• Share examples of Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander ways of knowing, being and doing. How are tools and designs shaped by Country, purpose and community needs.</li><li>• Talk with children about how designs tell stories and hold knowledge, just like traditional tools or artworks.</li><li>• Invite children to share their creations and thinking through drawing, storytelling or yarning.</li></ul>                                                                         |